

EDUCATION

Northeastern University

September 2025 - May 2030 (Expected)

Ph.D. in Political Science

Graduate Certificate in Computational Social Science

University of California, Irvine

September 2021 - June 2025

Bachelor of Arts in Criminology, Law and Society, magna cum laude

Bachelor of Arts in Education Sciences, summa cum laude

Cumulative GPA: 3.99

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Investigations to cultivate political engagement through the study of political discourse and rhetoric, with particular attention to how human rights issues are understood, discussed, and portrayed in society.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Summer Institute in Computational Social Science (SICSS) at Stanford University

August 2026

SICSS-Stanford Fellow

Selected participant in Stanford University's Summer Institute in Computational Social Science (SICSS-Stanford), focused on computational methods, AI systems, online environments, data collection, and research ethics.

Motivated Reframing Study

October 2025 - Present

Doctoral Researcher

Co-Principal Investigators: Thomas Nelson and Seo Eun "Sunny" Yang

An LLM-enabled interactive experiment testing whether individuals respond to belief-threatening information by changing political attitudes or by reframing the reasons underlying their belief systems.

- Contributed to experimental design, treatment intervention, and operationalization of motivated reframing.
- Evaluated and compared survey platforms and LLMs (e.g., pricing models, scalability, and research constraints) to inform study feasibility and budget decisions.
- Developed a chatbot-style Qualtrics survey using R to implement pretest-posttest designs, randomized treatment conditions, and LLM-facilitated arguments tailored to respondents' stated reasons for beliefs.

Language and Learning Analytics Lab

January 2024 - August 2025

Lead Research Assistant | UC Irvine School of Education

Faculty Mentor: Nia Nixon

- Collected and preprocessed large-scale textual data using automated pipelines for downstream NLP analyses.
- Developed knowledge in machine learning and computational methods, including techniques such as word embeddings, topic modeling, Python-based NLP libraries, prompt engineering, and knowledge graphs.
- Supported a study leveraging LLMs for data augmentation, addressing data class imbalance and algorithmic bias.
- Designed formal models to standardize linguistic alignment, measuring conversation and interaction quality.

Measuring Undergraduate Success Trajectories (MUST) Project

October 2023 - August 2025

Research Assistant | UC Irvine School of Education

Faculty Mentor: Richard Arum

- Awarded Summer 2024 research funding for the College-to-Career (pipeline) Project, examining inequality in career services engagement between first-generation and continuing-generation students.
- Supported data preparation and project workflows, including data cleaning and codebook organization.
- Optimized SPSS syntax to improve data management efficiency.
- Selected for funding to lead the development of a data cleaning pipeline and data analysis curriculum in R.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE CONTINUED

Career Pathways for Research in Learning, Education, Analytics and Data Science (CP-LEADS) Program

January 2024 - December 2024

Research Fellow | UC Irvine School of Education

Faculty Advisors: Nia Nixon and Fernando Rodriguez

A year-long data science fellowship and research training program focused on (1) individual mentorship and community building, (2) developing technical skills in statistical analysis and data science, and (3) collaborative research.

- Conducted an independent faculty-mentored research project, including web scraping, NLP-based text analysis, and statistical testing, resulting in a report, oral presentation, and reproducible data notebook.
- Developed proficiency in R programming, including data manipulation and ggplot2 data visualizations.

AERA Undergraduate Student Education Research Training Workshop

April 2024

Research Fellow | American Educational Research Association Conference

Selected as one of 18 undergraduate researchers across the nation to engage in a rigorous three-day workshop and present research in a poster session at the National Conference in Philadelphia.

Disrupting Racism Lab | Racial Justice in Organizations (RJIO)

September 2022 - June 2024

Research Assistant | UC Irvine School of Education

Faculty Mentor: Adriana Villavicencio

Center for Racial Justice in Education (CRJE) partnership on behalf of the UCI School of Education and RJIO.

- Investigated the outcome of an external partner on New York high schools' progress toward racial justice.
- Focused on the capacity of school systems to effectively integrate anti-racist initiatives into organizational structures, routines, and policies (i.e., systematize racial justice).
- Built a strong foundation in organizational change theory, anti-racism frameworks, and critical race theory.
- Led a faculty-mentored project, culminating in an oral paper presentation and two poster presentations.
- Contributed to systematic literature reviews and a meta-synthesis of anti-racist professional development.
- Led focus group interviews with school faculty and staff, and conducted qualitative data analysis on Dedoose.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Defense Industrial Base Institute (DIBI)

September 2025 - Present

Doctoral Research Assistant

Based at Northeastern University with partners across the defense ecosystem, DIBI researchers identify critical challenges and mobilize the expertise, funding, and stakeholders needed to solve them at scale.

- Mapped a comprehensive stakeholder ecosystem, identifying manufacturers, government officials, school systems, economic developers, investors, and businesses to facilitate buy-in and public-private collaboration.
 - Produced a data report on actionable insights and data-driven recommendations to guide government agencies on structured partnership opportunities for the activation of private capital.
- Led data collection on the West Coast ecosystem, examining workforce development, social and economic infrastructure through interviews with stakeholders.

Northeastern University Interview Study

March 2025 - Present

Research Collaborator; Co-author

- Conducted in-depth interviews with undergraduates, engaged in qualitative analysis and iterative codebook development (MAXQDA), and co-authored a manuscript.

Orange County District Attorney's Office

May 2022 - Sept 2022

Professional Responsibility & Training Unit

Legal Intern

- Served as primary liaison to victims' families, providing updates and clarifying case status to ensure transparent communication across archived and active cases; upholding Marsy's Law.
- Authored 300+ analytical memos on case details, law and policy changes, and procedural guidance.
- Retrieved official arrest/prosecution records to inform Deputy District Attorneys' (DDAs) decision-making.
- Synthesized case law, supporting continuing education practical exercises for DDAs and law enforcement.

PUBLICATIONS

Couts, F., Valencia-Lopez, E., **Shariff, D.**, & Arum, R (2026). Microcosms of the Labor Market: How Universities Sort Students into Specialized vs. Exploratory Co-ops. *Research Committee 28 on Social Stratification and Mobility (RC28)*. New York, New York.

Couts, F., Valencia-Lopez, E., **Shariff, D.**, & Arum, R (2026). Microcosms of the Labor Market: How Universities Sort Students into Specialized vs. Exploratory Co-ops. *American Sociological Association*. New York, New York.

Park, S., **Shariff, D.**, Samadi, A., Nixon, N., & D'Mello, S (2025). From Discourse to Dynamics: Understanding Team Interactions Through Temporally Sensitive NLP. *Educational Data Mining*.

Park, S., Nixon, N., D'Mello, S., & **Shariff, D** (2025). Understanding Collaborative Learning Processes and Outcomes Through Student Discourse Dynamics. *Learning Analytics & Knowledge. Association for Computing Machinery*.

Samadi, A., **Shariff, D.**, Ibarra, R (2025). Balancing the Scales: Using GPT-4 for Robust Data Augmentation. *Learning Analytics & Knowledge Conference*.

PUBLICATIONS IN PROGRESS

Shariff, D., & Nixon, N. (forthcoming). "The Language of Political Violence and Impunity: News Media Framing of Israel and Palestine."

Shariff, D., & Yang, S. (forthcoming). "A World Court for Whom? Machine Learning Evidence of Bias in Legal Discourse."

Shariff, D., Cusimano, A., McMahon, S. & Arum, R. (forthcoming). "How news consumption impacts civic reasoning."

Nelson, T. E., Yang, S., **Shariff, D.** & Leeson, N. (forthcoming). "Motivated Reframing."

Shariff, D. (forthcoming). "The human cost of machine algorithms."

POSTERS AND PRESENTATIONS

Shariff, D. (July 2026). A World Court for Whom? Machine Learning Evidence of Bias in Legal Discourse. Spoken presentation at the 36th Annual Meeting of the Society for Text and Discourse in Charlotte, North Carolina.

Shariff, D. (February 2025). The Language of Political Violence: News Media Framing of Israel and Palestine. Poster presented at the 2025 Winter Text & Discourse (WT&D) Conference in Boulder, Colorado.

Shariff, D. (July 2024). Exploring News Media Bias with Natural Language Processing. Presented at the University of California, Irvine, for the CP-LEADS 2024 Summer Symposium.

Shariff, D., & Khan, Z. (May 2024). Systematizing Racial Justice in Schools. Presented at the University of California, Irvine, for the 2024 Undergraduate Research Symposium Oral Spotlights themed evening "Impacts".

Shariff, D. (May 2024). Exploring News Media Bias with Natural Language Processing Tools. Poster presented at the University of California, Irvine, for the Undergraduate Research Opportunities Program (UROP) Poster Showcase.

Shariff, D. (April 2024). Systematizing Racial Justice in Educational Institutions. Poster presented at the Philadelphia Convention Center, for the 2024 AERA Undergraduate Fellows Research Poster Fair.

CERTIFICATIONS

College of Social Sciences and Humanities at Northeastern University	September 2025 - April 2026 (Expected)
Certificate in <i>Computational Social Science</i>	
Leveraging Big Data, machine learning, and predictive analytics to tackle pressing issues in public policy.	

Data Analysis Programming Workshop at UC Irvine
Certificate in *R* for Reproducible Scientific Analysis

April 2024 - June 2024

SKILLS

Computer: Microsoft Word, Powerpoint, Excel, Adobe Photoshop, Illustrator, Premiere Pro

Language: R, SPSS, Python, SQL

Additional Skills: Dedoose, STATA, MAXQDA, Qualtrics, QuestionPro

TEACHING AND MENTORING EXPERIENCE

Language and Learning Analytics Lab

June 2024 - June 2025

Project Coordinator | UC Irvine School of Education

Principal Investigator: Nia Nixon

- Spearheaded recruitment of undergraduate research assistants, building a skilled team to support expanding research initiatives and project growth.
- Mentored new members, providing research training and facilitating seamless integration into project workflows.
- Launched and managed a social media strategy to increase the lab's online visibility and public engagement.
- Co-hosted a podcast at the UCI ANTreprenuer Center, promoting lab projects and academic publications.

UCI Early Academic Outreach Program (EAOP)

College Advisor

September 2024 - December 2024

Mentored first-generation high school students from underrepresented communities to increase their access to higher education opportunities and strengthen college readiness.

Education 224: Text as Data

April 2024 - June 2024

Lectured on topic modeling and facilitated discussions, demonstrating practical applications of NLP methods.

Rancho Cucamonga Library

September 2018 - August 2022

Student Teaching Assistant

Worked intimately with K-5 students on writing, reading, and speech skills.

HONORS AND AWARDS

Walter Kintsch Student Travel Award	July 2026
Educational Data Mining (EDM) 2025 Best Short Paper	July 2025
Outstanding Contribution to the Community Award - University of California, Irvine	June 2025
Nellie Ansley Reeves Thesis Award - UCI Libraries	June 2025
Dean's Scholar Award - University of California, Irvine	June 2025
Dean's Honors List	9 Quarters - 2021, 2022, 2023, 2024
Language and Learning Analytics Lab Conference Funding	April 2025
Student Travel Award - Winter Text & Discourse Conference 2025	March 2025
UROP Travel Award	December 2024
Campuswide Honors Collegium Conference Funding	November 2024
Chancellor's Award for Excellence in Research	June 2024
Phi Beta Kappa Honor Society	June 2023 - June 2025
UROP Oral Presentation Finalist	May 2024
AERA Undergraduate Workshop Fellowship	April 2024
UROP 2023 Research Experience Fellowship	2023 - 2024
Neon Anteater Renaissance (NAR) Winter Finalist	February 2022